

Panel: RISC-V in 2026

Where the Ecosystem Stands, and Where Canada Fits

30 September 2026 · Bell Theatre, Carleton University

Panelists Mike Thompson, OpenHW Foundation
hardware and verification
Scott Bambrough, RISCstar
software and product

Arash Ahmadi, Carleton University
academic
Trevor Gamblin, BayLibre
software and toolchains

Moderator Yusef Karim, RISC-V Ottawa

INTRODUCTIONS

Yusef introduces each panelist, then one question down the line

1 ALL PANELISTS

Where does RISC-V actually show up in a typical day for you?

CATEGORY 1

Is RISC-V production-ready?

2 MIKE

In 2026, which parts of the RISC-V hardware ecosystem are mature, and which parts are still rough?

→ if it is all sunny, then ask: are there any thorny areas you feel you need to warn people about?

3 TREVOR

Same question on the software side: where is the RISC-V software stack genuinely mature today, and where is it still rough?

→ if it stays high level: the specific thing that broke on you most recently?

→ **CROSS-TALK · SCOTT**

You have heard the hardware answer and the software answer. The type of software RISCstar works on is close to hardware. Which side causes the most headache for you?

CATEGORY 2

When is choosing RISC-V worth it?

4 ARASH

For a specialized computing task, when is RISC-V the right choice over an alternative that already works?

→ how do you compare? what number would you look at?

- 5 SCOTT**
From a product perspective, what single factor most often decides whether a RISC-V advantage is worth the software and integration investment it demands?
→ have you seen a team get that call wrong?
- **CROSS-TALK · ARASH**
That is how it goes in a company. In an academic lab, do the factors change?

CATEGORY 3

What can Canadian labs and companies sustain together?

- 6 ARASH**
Drawing on what you see in Canadian labs, name one piece of RISC-V work a university and an industry partner could usefully tackle together.
→ and what keeps it alive after the student graduates or the grant ends?
- **CROSS-TALK · MIKE**
If Arash's team brought that to OpenHW, what makes it usable outside his lab, and what needs to be settled first before wide use?

CATEGORY 4

Where can someone here start?

- 7 TREVOR**
For a student or developer with some programming experience, a laptop, and no RISC-V hardware, what is one first project or contribution they could realistically finish in a month?
- 8 MIKE**
For someone who wants to understand how a RISC-V processor actually works, or learn to test one, what is one manageable first exercise, and where do they find it?
- 9 SCOTT**
For an engineer who wants to explore RISC-V at work without committing the company to a platform change, what small evaluation would you have them run first?
- 10 ARASH**
For an instructor or a research supervisor who wants to introduce RISC-V without redesigning a whole course or research program, what is one small thing they could try first?
- **CROSS-TALK · ALL FOUR**
If good on time: anyone want to add anything else here on where people can get started? Ten seconds each.

CLOSER

The gap worth filling

- 11 MIKE, THEN ARASH, THEN OPEN TO THE REST FOR FINAL COMMENTS**
In one or two sentences each: what skill is genuinely scarce in the Canadian RISC-V talent pool right now?
Audience questions follow.